

THE ACCOUNTS FOR THE MANOR OF ESHER IN
THE WINCHESTER PIPE ROLLS, 1235–1376

1. c. 29 September 1235 to c. 29 September 1236

This is the first account for Esher that appears on the Winchester Pipe Rolls. As there is a gap in the rolls between 1232/3 and 1235/6, it seems likely that Esher was purchased by Bishop Peter des Roches from the abbey of Croix St Leufroy at some point between 29 September 1233 and 29 September 1235. Since the Esher account for 1235/6 refers to a 'preceding account', he may in fact have acquired the manor by 29 September 1234, although we cannot be certain that this preceding account covered the full accounting year. The first surviving account, for 1235/6, is relatively short but nevertheless highly informative. In particular, it gives the impression that the manor at this time was small, rudimentary, and in a fairly run-down state; as discussed in the introduction, it is likely that the monks of Croix St Leufroy had been absentee landlords and leased out the demesne. Only 20 quarters of corn, reportedly covering 26 acres of land, was sown on the demesne in 1235/6.¹ The only buildings mentioned by name at the manorial centre were a grange and an oxshed; the roofs of both required patching (and the oxshed needed to be propped in 1236/7),² while a third building was taken down. A new sheep house was also built, stocked with sheep from four other manors on the bishop's estate. The account also provides an interesting commentary on the impact of weather conditions on agriculture and, possibly, health. We know from other sources that 1236 was a year of extreme weather, with monsoon-like conditions and flooding between January and mid-March, followed by drought between then and August.³ This account suggests either that no winter-sown corn was planted at Esher or that none survived. It also reveals that five heriots were received from peasants, perhaps reflecting environmental conditions highly favourable to the transmission of various diseases.⁴

HRO, 11M59/B1/16, *rot* 16r.

From Christmas until the feast of St Michael Peter the serjeant renders account because Walter Barat rendered account from the feast of St Michael in the same year until Christmas and all respect and allowance was made for the said term.

Peter the serjeant renders account for 28s 9½d of arrears from the past year. All was paid to Lord Robert de Clinch.⁵

¹ Although the sown acreage was said to have been measured 'by the perch', the amount of seedcorn (and later sowing rates) suggests that the amount of land sown may in fact have been closer to 40 acres.

² HRO, 11M59/B1/17.

³ Kington, *Climate and weather*, pp. 209–10.

⁴ Livi-Bacci, *Population and nutrition*; Dobson, *Contours of death*; Stone, 'Impact of drought', pp. 446–52.

⁵ 'Lord', 'dominus', was used to denote a member of the non-graduate clergy. Robert de Clinch was the bishop's treasurer, who was in charge of the estate's finances.

The same renders account for 73s 1d from all rent for Esher. For 6d from increment of rent for downland,⁶ which Stephen and Martin de Wexford hold. For 2d from increment of rent for one curtilage of Cleibrigg that Martin de Wexford holds. For 100s from the lease of a certain tenement at Charlton next to Blandford in the county of Dorset.⁷ For 20s from the perpetual pension of the church of Esher.⁸ Sum with rent £9 13s 9d.

The same renders account for one ploughshare from the rent of Samson de Mulclea for 1 acre of land; and it remains. The same renders account for 50s received from Lord Robert de Clinch. The same renders account for 11s from pannage. For 11s from 2 plough beasts. For 21s 6d from 3 cows. For 5d from the pelts of 7 wethers after shearing. For 2d from 1 goose from rent. For 14d from 14 hens. For 3½[d] from 40 eggs. Sum 45s 4½d.

Corn sold

The same renders account for 13s 6½d from 12½ quarters of oats.

Perquisites

The same renders account for 4s from the tithing of Esher for exactions relaxed. For 20s from Stephen de Wexford for reserving his land for his life.⁹ For 12d from Basilia for an entry fine. For 12d from Sybil for the same. Sum 26s.

Sum of all receipts £16 8s 8d.

Payments

In payment to Lord R de Clinch £6 17s 2d.

Expenses

In ironwork on one plough for three terms 14d. In stipend of a smith 15d. In one new plough bought and another repaired 6d. In 3 quarters of barley bought 6s. In 9 quarters 6 bushels of mancorn¹⁰ 21s 2½d. In 19 quarters 5 bushels of oats 22s ½d. In herrings bought for the work of carrying and harrowing 3d. In cheese bought for the work of mowing the meadow of Brodemed and carrying hay 6d. In levelling the meadow and clearing the downland 4½d. In fish and cheese bought for three harvest boons this year of 92 men 19d. In meat for the same 15d. In ale for the same 12d. In pottage for the same 4d. In weeding corn 6d. In a carpenter making one sheep house from new and mowing straw for the same and roofing the same 10s 2d. In roofing the grange and the oxshed in places 4d. In removing a small gate and a building 4d. In two wheels for the wagon 21d. In repairing the same 2½d. In clouts and grease for the same 3d. In repairing the ditch of Rihull 6d. In a hedge enclosing

⁶ In MS, '*t[er]ra de dune*'.

⁷ This land was presumably included with the purchase of the manor from the abbey of Croix St Leufroy.

⁸ This perpetual pension, a fixed annual sum taken from the profits of the church, had perhaps been granted by the bishopric of Winchester to the monks of Croix St Leufroy. See also doc. 6.

⁹ In MS, literally 'for his term'.

¹⁰ Probably maslin, a mixture of wheat and rye: Titow, 'Land and population', pp. 33-5.

the *curia* 6d. In 20 hurdles¹¹ for the fold 21d. In making 10 hurdles 3d. In a little bell for a wether 1d. In ruddle for the ewes 3½[d]. In threshing and winnowing 2½ quarters of rye and ½ quarter of barley and 12 quarters of oats 16½d. In stipend of two ploughmen for the year 7s. In stipend of one shepherd for 17 weeks 12d. In one shovel bought ½d. In expenses of the steward for two visits 19½d. In robes for the serjeant 15s. In payment of the same from Christmas until the feast of St Michael for 278 days 46s 4d. Sum £7 6s 7½d.

Sum of payments and expenses £14 3s 9½d.

And he owes 44s 10½d.

Issue of the grange

The same renders account for 2½ quarters from the issue of rye. All in payment of two *famuli* because they received the rest in mancorn and barley. The same renders account for ½ quarter from the issue of barley. For 3 quarters bought. Sum 3½ quarters. In sowing 2 acres by the perch 1 quarter. In payment of two *famuli* 2½ quarters. The same renders account for 9 quarters 6 bushels of mancorn bought. In payment of two *famuli* 4 quarters 6 bushels. In payment of one shepherd for 17 weeks 2 quarters 1 bushel. In customary payment to harrowers and for carrying corn from market ½ quarter.¹² In customary payment to mowers and carriers of hay 5 bushels. In bread for harvest boons and for the carriage of corn 1 quarter 6 bushels. The same renders account for 13 quarters 3 bushels from the issue of oats. For 19 quarters 5 bushels bought. Sum 33 quarters. In sowing 24 acres by the perch 19 quarters. In fodder for one harrowing 5 bushels. In fodder for the steward 7 bushels. Sold as above 12½ quarters.

The same renders account for 2 plough beasts from heriot. Sold as above 2, and none remain. The same renders account for 8 oxen that remained. And they remain. The same renders account for 3 cows from heriot. Sold 3 and none remain. Likewise he renders account for 50 wethers received from Hambledon. For 50 from Cheriton. For 50 from Sutton. For 50 from Alresford. Sum 200. 7 died. In customary payment to the mowers of the meadow 1. Sum 8. And 192 remain. The same renders account for 1 goose that remained. For 1 from rent. Sum 2. Sold as above 1. And 1 remains. The same renders account for 14 hens from rent. Sold as above 14. The same renders account for 40 eggs that remained. For 40 from rent. Sum 80. Sold as above 40. And 40 eggs remain.

2. 4 April to c. 29 September 1245¹³

The manor of Esher was not bought by Peter des Roches with the aim of enhancing the estate of the bishopric of Winchester; instead, he intended it to form part of the endowment of a new Cistercian monastery, Netley Abbey in Hampshire. Although

¹¹ In MS, '*cra*l'; the hurdles in the next entry are '*cla*l'.

¹² The nearest market to Esher was held at Cobham. It had been granted in the reign of King Stephen (1135–54) and was held on a Tuesday: Letters, *Online gazetteer of markets and fairs* [Surrey].

¹³ In MS, above the title 'Essere', is written 'Wednesday after St Martin' [15 November]. This was the day on which the scribe wrote the entry for Esher in the Pipe Rolls.